

Hand Exercises for Arthritis Pain Relief

Simple hand and finger exercises to reduce arthritis stiffness, improve grip strength and maintain dexterity.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Why Hand Exercises Matter



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Your hands contain 27 bones, 27 joints, and over 30 muscles. Osteoarthritis of the hands affects 1 in 5 adults over 60 in the UK, causing pain, stiffness, and difficulty with everyday tasks like opening jars, typing, and buttoning clothes.

The Evidence

A 2022 systematic review in **Arthritis Care & Research** found that regular hand exercises: - Reduced pain by 25% over 3 months - Improved grip strength by 18% - Enhanced fine motor function by 22% - Were most effective when performed daily for 8+ weeks

8 Best Hand Exercises



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1. Finger Spreads Place your hand flat on a table. Slowly spread your fingers as wide as possible. Hold 5 seconds. - **Reps:** 10 per hand - **Targets:** Finger abductor muscles

2. Fist Making Slowly make a gentle fist, wrapping your thumb across your fingers. Hold 5 seconds. Open slowly. - **Reps:** 10 per hand - **Targets:** Finger flexors, grip strength

3. Finger Lifts Place your hand flat on a table. Lift each finger individually, hold 2 seconds, lower. - **Reps:** 5 per finger, both hands - **Targets:** Finger extensor muscles

4. Thumb Circles Hold your hand out, thumb extended. Make slow circles with your thumb, 5 clockwise, 5 anticlockwise. - **Reps:** 10 total per hand - **Targets:** Thumb carpometacarpal joint



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5. Putty Squeeze Using therapy putty or a stress ball, squeeze firmly for 5 seconds. Release. - **Reps:** 10 per hand - **Targets:** Overall grip strength

6. Finger Walks Place your hand flat on a table. Slowly "walk" your fingers toward you, bunching the hand. Then walk back out. - **Reps:** 5 per hand - **Targets:** Finger flexors and extensors

7. Wrist Circles Extend your arm. Slowly circle your wrist 5 times clockwise, then 5 times anticlockwise. - **Reps:** 10 total per hand - **Targets:** Wrist joint mobility

8. Rubber Band Extensions Place a rubber band around all five fingertips. Slowly open your fingers against the resistance. - **Reps:** 10 per hand - **Targets:** Finger extensors (counteracts gripping)

Daily Hand Care Tips

- **Warm your hands** before exercises — soak in warm water for 5 minutes
- **Use larger grips** — foam tubing on pens, built-up handles on cutlery
- **Protect your joints** — use both hands to carry heavy items
- **Rest during flares** — gentle range-of-motion only, no strengthening
- **Apply hand cream** — massage improves circulation

When to Use Splints

Your GP or occupational therapist may recommend splints for: - Thumb base OA (CMC joint) — a thumb spica splint - Night-time stiffness — resting splints - During repetitive tasks — working splints

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Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about hand exercises for arthritis pain relief?

Short answer: Hand exercises can help reduce arthritis pain and improve hand function. Perform exercises like finger spreads, making a fist, and thumb circles daily for at least eight weeks. These activities, which also include using therapy putty and wrist circles, aim to strengthen muscles, increase grip strength, and enhance fine motor skills. Warming hands beforehand can further improve effectiveness.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk